

Chapter 71-1: Not Afraid

Chapter 71-2: Not Afraid

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The jade was shattered and could not be restored to its original state, but fortunately Chu Qingqiu had collected all the pieces of the bracelet, and when put together it was still complete.

So Ning Fuyi rummaged through boxes and drawers to find several gold ornaments, snuck out of Zhuguang Pavilion, and sat alone in the moonlight, melting the gold beads from the ornaments. Using her divine sword, she hammered them into thin gold leaves and fixed them to the fractures of the bracelet.

Fortunately, the part carved with gardenia flowers was intact, so after this repair it didn't look unsightly. Although it no longer had the original transparent quality of pure jade, it gained a kind of golden, broken beauty.

However, this process sounded simple but was extremely time-consuming to execute. Either the gold leaves weren't hammered evenly, or the bracelet didn't fit together completely, exhausting Ning Fuyi to the point of breaking out in a sweat.

It wasn't until the moon in the sky had been worn down by clouds that she finally finished the repair. She let out a long breath, picked up the bracelet, and examined it against the lantern beside her.

Under the soft lamplight, the jade color was verdant and lustrous, with the gold leaves carved with flowers fitting seamlessly.

At this moment, Ning Fuyi's head began to ache again, as if several ants were gnawing inside her skull. She tucked the bracelet into her sleeve, covered her forehead, and gritted her teeth to endure it.

What was happening? She had examined herself earlier - there were no injuries in her body, her immortal veins were undamaged, she had no illness or disaster, so why was she experiencing such splitting headaches?

She waved her hand to summon her immortal power, using her fingers to press into her temples. Gentle pink light points flowed into her skin, and after a long while, the headache finally eased.

She wondered if Chu Qingqiu had rested yet. Perhaps she should deliver this jade bracelet and take the opportunity to ask why she was experiencing these inexplicable headaches. After deliberating, Ning Fuyi picked up the lantern and rose, walking along the night path toward Jingshan Palace.

At the same time, in the pavilion of Jingshan Palace, a single lamp burned at the foot of the bed, while the rest of the room was shrouded in darkness. The dim firelight only illuminated the bed and the silhouette of the person upon it.

The woman's slender body was curled up, her arms wrapped around her knees, her head leaning against the bed post, her skirt spread across the entire bed like blooming gardenia flowers.

Perhaps because she usually kept her shoulders straight, wrapping herself in loose clothing and an imposing aura, now that these external things were shed, she appeared even more fragile.

The door was knocked twice, and Qiuyi's careful voice sounded from outside: "Master... this disciple has prepared ginger tea¹ for you. Please drink some."

Chu Qingqiu's eyes moved slightly, turning her face further into the shadows, her voice gentle and indifferent: "I'm tired and don't want to drink."

Qiuyi stood outside the door holding the ginger tea, worry written all over her face. She stepped back two paces but was unwilling to leave: "Master, you haven't spoken a word since returning. This disciple... this disciple is truly worried about you..."

"I'm fine, it's just that too many things have happened, and I'm exhausted," Chu Qingqiu said again. "Leave the tea and go back."

Qiuyi bit her lip and stood for a long while, then crouched down outside the door, silently keeping watch.

So when Ning Fuyi climbed the steps, she saw someone crouched by the door, drowsy with sleep, and the scene of dim candlelight inside the room.

Ning Fuyi walked to the door, woke up the one who was dozing off with her head hanging down, then asked: "Where is the Divine Venerable?"

Qiuyi was startled by the sudden scare and nearly cried out, but suddenly remembering that Chu Qingqiu was resting, she swallowed back her voice and spoke in a whisper: "Do you even need to ask? Naturally she's inside!"

"What exactly happened between you two in Dongyue? Master has been absent-minded since returning, and won't say anything when asked. I'm going crazy with worry!" Qiuyi said as she climbed up from the ground, picking up the bowl of ginger tea.

"I died," Ning Fuyi answered briefly, pushing the door to enter.

"Died?" Qiuyi opened her mouth wide in shock, her face full of disbelief, then hurriedly grabbed Ning Fuyi, stuffing the still-warm ginger soup into her hands. "This is ginger soup I've brewed several times, with divine herbs² added for warming the body. Take it in to Master!"

"She'll only listen to you now!" Qiuyi pouted unwillingly.

Ning Fuyi glanced at her, then took the ginger soup, knocked twice on the door frame, and pushed the door open.

The lamp inside extinguished the moment she entered, and it was even colder inside than outside. Ning Fuyi closed the door behind her and took a step forward, the fragrance of gardenia flowers lingering at her nose.

Chu Qingqiu's voice came from the darkness: "Has my Jingshan Palace become your home? Coming and going as you please, without the slightest courtesy!"

"I came to bring you something," Ning Fuyi said, not using her divine consciousness and feeling her way forward in the dark. Just as her knee was about to hit the low table, candlelight flickered to life again. Chu Qingqiu was sitting cross-legged beside the table, her thin lips tightly pressed together.

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Ning Fuyi stopped walking, looked down at the corner of the table, hid the smile at the edge of her lips, composed herself and knelt down properly, placing the soup bowl in front of Chu Qingqiu.

"I won't drink it," Chu Qingqiu said indifferently.

"You really won't drink it?" Ning Fuyi picked up the bowl and smelled it at her nose. "Qiuyi's skills are quite good, this ginger tea smells fragrant."

As soon as she finished speaking, she suddenly felt a chill on her back, then her hand loosened as the bowl was snatched away by Chu Qingqiu using immortal power, landing heavily back on the table.

"Didn't I warn you before I left to stay well at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate? Ning Fuyi, when will you ever listen to a word I say!" Chu Qingqiu pressed her fist against the table surface, speaking in a low voice.

So she was angry because she hadn't listened. Ning Fuyi's hand turned the ice-cold bracelet in her sleeve: "But Divine Venerable, those demons knew you weren't at the gate, which is why they dared to attack boldly. At that time you were in the Eastern Wasteland, the other elders wouldn't believe what I said, and with Liu Wenzhu in mortal danger, I absolutely couldn't delay, so I took the risk."

"This isn't my fault either..." Ning Fuyi lowered her voice slightly, her eyelashes downcast.

Chu Qingqiu's red lips parted slightly, and she was momentarily speechless. Finally, she flicked her sleeve and turned to stand up, smoothing the frustration in her heart.

After a moment, she spoke: "Forget it. If I hadn't left at that time, I wouldn't have given those demons an opportunity to exploit."

The sun was rising from the bottom up³ - Chu Qingqiu was actually giving someone else a way out? Ning Fuyi looked up in surprise, then supported herself on the table to stand and walked behind her.

She took out the repaired jade bracelet from her sleeve, reached her arm around Chu Qingqiu's side, and waved the bracelet in front of her.

Chu Qingqiu's movements paused, her palm involuntarily tightening on her clothing hem as she looked down at the bracelet.

Ning Fuyi's hands were very skillful - even the gold leaves were carved with patterns, seamlessly concealing the fracture marks.

Seeing that she didn't speak, Ning Fuyi's skirt fluttered as she turned back to face her, forcibly lifting Chu Qingqiu's arm and putting the bracelet on her wrist. Chu Qingqiu struggled a bit at first, but when the bracelet touched her skin, she stopped moving and let Ning Fuyi handle her.

"Isn't this good," Ning Fuyi smiled. "It's still the original one, yet now it's unique."

Chu Qingqiu gently moved her arm, and the cool bracelet clinked against her other bracelets, making a crisp tinkling sound.

"Divine Venerable, you're not sad anymore, right?" Ning Fuyi leaned forward slightly to look at Chu Qingqiu's glassy eyes, but was blocked by her own suddenly flying sleeves.

"Don't mention this matter again in the future," Chu Qingqiu said, then walked around her back to the bed and sat down with a flutter of her robes.

Ning Fuyi turned to follow her, feeling somewhat puzzled in her heart. She didn't know why, but since she had entered the door, Chu Qingqiu hadn't looked at her directly, as if deliberately avoiding her gaze.

Could it be that her adult appearance was really so frightening? Ning Fuyi casually conjured a bronze mirror and held it in front of her face, looking left and right. Her eyebrows were like curved hooks, her phoenix eyes slightly upturned, her lips red and teeth white. When she smiled, the corners of her mouth were pointed - not very proper.

But because she lacked the two teardrop moles from her previous life, she also had less demonic aura. By all accounts, she should be considered a beauty.

"What are you still doing here?" Chu Qingqiu said, looking at the candlelight before her.

Only then did Ning Fuyi remember her headache issue. She lowered her hand to put away the bronze mirror and was about to speak when a violent pain suddenly pierced through her entire skull. This time it was several times more unbearable than before. She couldn't help but let out a low groan, her knees going weak as she fell forward.

Chu Qingqiu, sitting on the bed, saw her movement and immediately transformed into a fleeting shadow, instantly standing in front of her. In her urgency, she caught Ning Fuyi around the waist: "Ning Fuyi!"

Ning Fuyi collapsed into a cloud of fragrance. She tightly covered her head, her body involuntarily falling, the pain making her face pale as tears were about to fall.

Chu Qingqiu bit her lip hard, turned her hand to press Ning Fuyi down to sit on the bed, then turned around and blasted the door open with one palm, startling Qiuyi who was crouching outside and nearly making her fall from the pavilion.

"Master..."

"Quickly write a letter to Medical Immortal Jiang⁴, saying there's an urgent matter requesting her assistance. Have Bai Lin⁵ deliver it to the Jiang family at Witch Mountain!" Chu Qingqiu said.

Qiuyi saw Ning Fuyi on Chu Qingqiu's bed, breaking out in cold sweat, and slowed her steps: "This..."

"Go quickly!" Chu Qingqiu shouted, and only then did Qiuyi respond affirmatively, hurriedly leaping from the railing, her figure disappearing.

Chu Qingqiu waved her hand to close the door properly. Not caring about propriety, she put one arm around Ning Fuyi and slipped her other hand under her knees, laying her body horizontally on the bed.

Then she drew her fingers across her brow, bringing out threads of silver-white immortal power and injecting them into Ning Fuyi's forehead. But after examining her repeatedly, she found not the slightest injury.

"How can this be..." Chu Qingqiu frowned and murmured to herself.

The woman in her arms was already soaked in cold sweat. She was almost shaking, rolling left and right in unbearable pain, her hands involuntarily climbing up Chu Qingqiu's waist.

The pain made her consciousness blur. It seemed that holding onto something would make her feel better, so without caring about anything else, she curled up and burrowed into Chu Qingqiu's embrace.

Chu Qingqiu's body went rigid from the warm, soft body in her arms, her heartbeat becoming chaotic as tangled hemp. She could only close her eyes, turn her right hand in a circle in mid-air, forcing immortal power from her palm to flow continuously into Ning Fuyi's body, temporarily suppressing her six senses⁶.

With her six senses suppressed, the pain would naturally lessen. Ning Fuyi's writhing gradually decreased, her breathing no longer so rapid, but the hands holding Chu Qingqiu's waist hadn't let go - instead, they gripped even tighter.

Chu Qingqiu withdrew her immortal technique and felt somewhat drained. With Ning Fuyi's arms around her waist, she couldn't stand steady and nearly fell onto Ning Fuyi. She quickly reached out to support herself.

The familiar face nearly touched her nose - the woman's sharp, bright features were covered with sweat drops, like frost-covered flowers in the morning.

Chu Qingqiu's breathing became erratic, her eyes flickering slightly.

As Ning Fuyi's pain faded, immense fatigue followed. She weakly grasped at Chu Qingqiu's collar.

"It hurts so much..." she said softly, as if subconsciously treating Chu Qingqiu as a lifeline, only able to cry out her pain to her.

After speaking, her consciousness finally fell into darkness.

Seeing her finally unconscious, Chu Qingqiu actually breathed a sigh of relief. Her lips were red as if about to drip blood. She stared at that face for a long time before looking away, her eyelashes trembling.

Then she reached out to wipe away the sweat drops on Ning Fuyi's forehead, speaking to herself: "Don't be afraid anymore."

"I'm here."

Footnotes:

¹ **Ginger tea (姜茶)** - A traditional Chinese remedy believed to warm the body and aid digestion, commonly consumed when one feels unwell or cold.

² **Divine herbs (神草)** - Supernatural medicinal plants with magical properties, common in cultivation novels for healing and enhancing one's abilities.

³ **The sun was rising from the bottom up (太阳打脚底下出来了)** - A Chinese idiom meaning something extremely rare or unexpected is happening, similar to "the sun rising in the west."

⁴ **Medical Immortal Jiang (江医仙)** - Refers to Jiang Li, a character who has achieved immortality through medical arts and is renowned for her healing abilities.

⁵ **Bai Lin (白麟)** - Literally "White Qilin," likely referring to a divine beast or spirit companion used for delivering messages.

⁶ **Six senses (六识)** - In Buddhist philosophy, the six consciousnesses: sight, hearing, smell, taste, touch, and mind/thought.